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**Saket Subramaniam**

Partner, Netbrain Solutions

## Enhance your Warranty

Your warranty takes care of your computer troubles for about a year or longer depending on the product you buy. But what if you need support after that and can't take care of it yourself? That's what Annual Maintenance Contracts (AMCs) are meant for.

You can sign up with an AMC after your warranty ends, at the time of or even after buying your computer. Rates for AMCs differ from dealer to dealer but normally work out to around Rs 2,500 to Rs 3,000 annually. AMCs normally cover onsite service only or installation to ensure that your PC works fine. It doesn't cover the cost of hardware. Branded PCs such as HP and Compaq too have 'warranty enhancements' which you can purchase at the time of purchasing your computer or a couple of days after purchasing your computer. For example, the Carepaq warranty enhancement for Compaq computers worldwide covers hardware services and software support for up to three years. So remember to ask your dealer for warranty enhancement options or AMCs, evaluate carefully and pick the one based on the kind of support that you're likely to need.

have to take care of that yourself. “Considering the margins at which we operate, it does not prove cost effective to follow up after the one-year warranty expires,” says Saket Subramaniam, a partner at Netbrain Solutions which deals in branded and assembled PCs. “You'll have no problems getting the component serviced or replaced if you contact the manufacturer's service centre with the product serial number.” Some assemblers will transact with the company but at an extra charge. You should also check the exact number of days your warranty covers. You should get a 365-day warranty from the dealer you buy your computer from as some manufacturers such as Zenith, IBM or HP offer their dealers and resellers warranties of more than a year—about 13 to 15 months—to take into account the time it takes to sell the product.

Your warranty begins from the date the product is sold to you. It is strictly performance related and is declared void in case of physical damage to the product. “The warranty doesn't

cover transportation of the component or product; for instance, a hard disk experiencing shocks during transportation,” says Zaveri, of Big Byte Computers. He adds that breaking of the warranty seal or burn marks on the printed circuit board (PCB) due to a short circuit also declares the warranty void.

So if you've decided to assemble your own PC, there's no problem at all. Just buy all the components from authorised dealers and get your warranty on individual components, but be sure to choose components from reputed brands

If a company Web site states that you get a three-year warranty, you might want to check out the duration of the warranty that distributors in India will offer you. In the case of certain products, for instance, Seagate hard disks, dealers in India offer only a one-year warranty even though it has a three-year warranty all over the world. If the product manufacturer has a Replacement Material Acceptance (RMA) centre in your country, then getting the benefit of the full warranty is no problem. But if the RMA centre is in a different country then you will have to reckon with the two-way customs clearance and duty payment involved in transporting the product to that country.

## Trading in the relics

That 6 GB hard disk you bought a while back has a problem and you need to get it replaced. Fortunately for you, it's within your warranty period. But wait a second. There aren't any 6 GB hard disks in the market. What do you do?

“We generally keep a buffer stock of older

## Buyer's Checklist

- ✓ Find the configuration of your PC and opt for components from reputed manufacturers having a well-defined warranty policy. All reputed manufacturers have Web sites with the terms of warranties on various products spelt out. Read them.
- ✓ While choosing the brand of a PC or components, ensure that it's reputed and offers good service infrastructure in your city. Such components are worth the slightly higher price you pay for them.
- ✓ Make sure the brand you're purchasing has a service centre in your city.
- ✓ Check out the background of the dealer or assembler.
- ✓ Insist on a written warranty with the dealer's stamp and signature, clearly stating that you have a warranty on your computer for a stipulated period. Check for whether it's a replacement, repair, a carry-in or an onsite warranty.
- ✓ Get someone who knows about computers

- to check your machine as soon as it reaches you to ensure that all components are in order.
- ✓ Beware of fake motherboards. To ensure you're not getting RAM that has been used before, look out for signatures on it. When RAM is sold or serviced, dealers usually sign on the RAM or on stickers attached to the RAM.
- ✓ When you're giving in a component for repair, look for an identification to ensure you're getting your own product back. Most dealers sign with a marker on the board every time the product goes in for servicing.
- ✓ Don't simply 'go, buy a computer'. If you don't know what the inside of a computer looks like, take along someone who does. Ask the assembler questions about warranties and service.
- ✓ Don't bother with a warranty of more than three years. Technology changes rapidly. What you got three years back is likely to have been replaced by newer models.